

players bring leadership skills and superior tactical acumen to any side they feature in. Both are opening batters who can accelerate at will, but what singles them out is consistency — a priceless combination in the slam-bang world of T20 cricket.

Money's worth

Cricket globally has pivoted towards all-rounders. Having a second skill makes a player significantly more 'value for money' for a franchise. The retention exercise restructured the top-earners' bracket as well. Currently, five players are in the ₹3 crore-and-above category. Mumbai Indians' Nat Sciver-Brunt (retained for a higher price than skipper Harmanpreet Kaur at ₹3.2 crore) is a frontline new-ball bowler besides being one of the most solid batters across formats. Alongside Gujarat Giants' off-spin-bowling explosive batter Ashleigh Gardner, the pair commanded the highest retention

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fee of ₹3.5 crore.

Deepti Sharma, acquired by the Warriorz for ₹2.6 crore in 2023, drew ₹60 lakh more this time. The WPL unlocked a new gear in her already solid batting abilities, pairing nicely with her effective off-spin. New Zealand all-rounder Amelia Kerr, known for her sublime strokeplay and lethal googlies, rounds off the list with a ₹3 crore tag — a threefold appreciation from her ₹1 crore price tag with Mumbai Indians in 2023. The White Ferns' T20 World Cup-winning captain Sophie Devine also commanded a ₹2 crore price tag for her utility with bat and ball.

The 2026 auction also showed how no parts of the jungle in the women's game remain unexplored. Scouts and coaches have their eyes and ears open in an almost entirely data-driven ecosystem, on the lookout for new talent

